

Boston Tea Party

Examine how Patriots, British officials, tea merchants, and other colonists viewed taxation, resistance, and British authority.

? Historical challenge

On the night of December 16, 1773, colonists boarded three ships in Boston Harbor and threw 342 chests of East India Company tea into the water. Was this a bold defense of colonial rights, reckless destruction of property, or something in between? Investigate the sources, then map how four different groups saw the same event.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Massachusetts Historical Society – Boston Tea Party collection

PRIMARY SOURCE

Eyewitness primary sources, including John Rowe's diary entry for December 16, 1773 and a letter from John Andrews describing the tea being thrown overboard.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does an eyewitness describe what happened at Griffin's Wharf?
- What does the writer's word choice suggest about their point of view?

SOURCES 2

DPLA – The Boston Tea Party (primary source set)

PRIMARY SOURCE

A curated set of primary sources: a period map of Boston showing Griffin's Wharf, and documents about the tea and the colonists' response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Where were the ships docked, and why did location matter?
- Which groups appear in these sources — and which do not?

SOURCES 3

American Battlefield Trust – “Boston a Teapot Tonight!”

SECONDARY SOURCE

A secondary article giving background: the Tea Act of 1773, the meetings at Old South Meeting House, and Britain's response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did the Tea Act of 1773 anger many colonists even though it made tea cheaper?
- What did Britain do after the tea was destroyed?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in each group's card from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a card blank if the sources don't tell you.



Patriots (Sons of Liberty)

S1

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

Repeal of the Tea Act and an end to taxation without representation; the right of colonists to govern their own trade and consent to taxes.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That Parliament could tax the colonies without their consent, and that the East India Company monopoly would ruin colonial merchants and set a precedent.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Held mass meetings at the Old South Meeting House; when the governor refused to send the ships back, a group (some disguised as Mohawks) boarded the Dartmouth, Eleanor, and Beaver at Griffin's Wharf and threw 342 chests of tea into the harbor.

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

① eyewitness diaries/letters (Rowe, Andrews); ③ background on the meetings and the Tea Act.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Britain retaliated with the Coercive (Intolerable) Acts in 1774, which closed Boston's port and pushed the colonies toward united resistance.



British Officials

S2

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

Colonists to pay the tea duty and obey Parliament; to uphold the Tea Act of 1773 and assert Britain's authority over the colonies.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That backing down would encourage more defiance and weaken control over all the colonies; continued smuggling.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Governor Thomas Hutchinson refused to let the tea ships leave the harbor without unloading and paying the duty. After the tea was destroyed, Parliament passed the Coercive Acts.

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

③ background on Hutchinson and Parliament's response; ② documents on the standoff.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Positions hardened; the Boston Port Act closed the harbor and troops were sent, deepening the conflict.

Boston Tea Party

December 16, 1773

Griffin's Wharf, Boston



Tea Merchants

S3

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

To protect their livelihoods and trade; independent merchants wanted the monopoly stopped, while the appointed consignees wanted to sell the Company's tea.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That the East India Company's monopoly would undercut and ruin colonial merchants; that boycotts would cut their sales either way.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Many merchants had signed non-importation (boycott) agreements; the consignees (including relatives of the governor) tried to receive and sell the tea.

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

② and ③ describe the Tea Act's monopoly and the merchants' position; sources on non-importation.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Trade was disrupted by the port closure and by boycotts; merchants had to choose sides.



Other Colonists

S4

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

Fair treatment and lower costs; many supported boycotting British tea, while some just wanted stability and open trade.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

Higher prices, disorder, and punishment; being caught between Patriot pressure and British authority.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Thousands attended the meetings at Old South; many boycotted tea and drank substitutes; committees of correspondence spread the news between colonies.

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

② and ③ describe the mass meetings and the colony-wide boycott; committees of correspondence.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

The Coercive Acts punished all of Massachusetts, not just those who destroyed the tea, which built sympathy and led to the First Continental Congress (1774).

Compare the voices

Where did perspectives overlap?

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Where did they conflict?

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Whose perspective is missing from the sources?

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Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- With a partner, compare your cards. Where did you record the same thing? Where did your evidence differ?
- Which group's perspective was hardest to find in the sources? Why might that be?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The Tea Act of 1773 actually made tea cheaper, but it kept the existing Townshend duty and gave the East India Company a monopoly through chosen consignees. Patriots opposed it on principle — no taxation without representation — and to protect colonial merchants. The destruction was disciplined: participants damaged only the tea and swept the decks; the event was not called the “Boston Tea Party” until decades later.

Common misconceptions

- Not a tax increase — the tea was cheaper; the objection was to taxation without consent and to the monopoly.
- Not a chaotic riot — it was organized and targeted only the tea.
- The “Mohawk” disguise was symbolic and did not truly hide identities.
- The name “Boston Tea Party” came later (1820s–1830s), not in 1773.

Vocabulary

Tea Act, Townshend duty, monopoly, consignee, boycott / non-importation, Sons of Liberty, committee of correspondence, Coercive (Intolerable) Acts, “no taxation without representation,” Patriot / Loyalist.

Historical context

Dec. 16, 1773; a huge meeting at the Old South Meeting House; Samuel Adams and the Sons of Liberty; three ships (Dartmouth, Eleanor, Beaver) at Griffin's Wharf; 342 chests (~92,000 lbs) of East India Company tea. Britain's 1774 Coercive Acts closed Boston's port and led to the First Continental Congress and, in 1775, to Lexington and Concord.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was the destruction of the tea a justified defense of colonial rights, or did it go too far? Support your answer with evidence from at least two sources and at least two groups' perspectives.